Tezpur knew of the Se-la debacle when at 5.30 a.m. Major J. S. Datta, the brigade major, got through to IV Corps HQ and passed on the news that Se-la was being abandoned following the exodus of 2 Sikh LI and 1 Sikh. This was to be the last formal communiqué, after which there was a deathly silence from 62 Infantry Brigade. The information was relayed to Kaul who then spoke to Anant Pathania. Despite the drama of the previous evening, both were stunned by the lightning speed with which events had overtaken them. Pathania again asked for permission to withdraw 4 Division HQ; Kaul acquiesced without asking the former where he planned to withdraw to. Pathania then said he was closing down his HQ and moving from Dirang Dzong. Thereafter, the lines went dead and there was no further communication between Corps HQ and Division HQ.

In the early hours of 18 November, the situation in Dirang Dzong was outwardly calm. However, after Pathania's conversation with Kaul, the GOC summoned Brigadier Cheema, Commander 65 Infantry Brigade, and other senior officers to the Ops Room for a conference to discuss the situation.

Ever since 16 November when news had first come in that 5 Guards had been overrun trying to defend Poshing-la, Pathania had started becoming more and more worried. The GOC had also realized the folly of not having prepared Dirang Dzong as a defensive position, despite having 65 Infantry deployed around the Division HQ. His immediate reaction was to close ranks around Division HQ and the 19 MLI columns were ordered to fall back on Dirang Dzong. This was a lost opportunity, for both the Maratha columns were well suited to harass the Chinese lines of communication, having done all the hard work of getting into a good tactical position. The MLI columns had plenty of ammunition and were reasonably well stocked. However, on the evening of 17 November they were rather timidly withdrawn. As the first column started to pull back, the Chinese stayed on their heels. On the morning of 18 November, while the exhausted party was brewing tea, it was ambushed near Munna Camp and forty men were either killed or captured, the others barely managing to get away.

Meanwhile, at Dirang Dzong, the divisional conference was not about fighting it out with the Chinese; instead the focus was on the hopelessness of the situation and how best to get out. Strangely, neither the GOC nor the brigade commander seemed to be worried about either 4 Rajput or 19 MLI, so it came as a rude shock when a dishevelled Major Shaikh barged into the